

Chicago Tribune



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Illinoisans push for a new clean energy law

Lawmakers introduce bill with ambitious goal for large-scale storage

By Nara Schoenberg and Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

With clean energy under siege in Congress and in the Oval Office, supporters continue to press forward in Illinois.

Lawmakers have introduced the Clean and Reliable Grid Affordability Act, with an ambitious new goal for large-scale energy storage, in which giant batteries absorb wind and solar energy when it's not needed, and release it when it is.

The bill makes it easier to construct high-voltage transmission lines, which bring the cleanest, lowest-cost energy to consumers.

There are also measures promoting energy efficiency, addressing electricity-guzzling data centers and establishing virtual power plants — networks of homes with EVs, solar panels and batteries that, working in tandem, can produce large amounts of energy and save customers money.

"Trump has made it clear he plans to roll back federal funding and programs that support clean energy progress," Democratic state Rep. Ann Williams of Chicago, a sponsor of the bill, said at a news conference Tuesday.

"This is of great concern to all of us in Illinois, but we are not going back. Illinois can and will continue to lead on climate policy," she said.

President Donald Trump's efforts to block funding for solar and wind energy and electric vehicles have hit Illinois hard in recent weeks, with environmentalists reporting chaos and confusion.

But there's also a sense of pride in the state's sweeping 2021 law, the Climate and Equitable Jobs Act, and a determination to meet new challenges.

"Our power grid is struggling to keep up with a surge in demand for energy, largely caused by new data centers," Illinois Clean Jobs Coalition lobbyist Kady McFadden said

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President Donald Trump addresses a joint session of Congress at the Capitol in Washington on Tuesday. WIN MCNAMEE/AP

Trump vows to remain 'swift and unrelenting'

GOP allies applaud pledge to continue disruptive policies

By Zeke Miller and Michelle L. Price
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump vowed Tuesday to keep up his campaign of "swift and unrelenting action" in reorienting the nation's economy, immigration and foreign policy in an unyielding address to Congress and the nation that left Democratic legislators to register their dissent with stone faces, placards calling out "lies" and one legislator's ejection.

Trump's prime-time speech was the latest marker in his takeover of the nation's capital, where the Republican-led House and

Senate have done little to restrain him as he and his allies work to slash the size of the federal government and remake America's place in the world.

The address, more than 90 minutes long, added up to an defiant sales pitch for the policies that he promised during his campaign and leaned into during his first weeks back in office. Trump pledged to keep delivering sweeping changes to the country, rescuing it from what he described as destruction and mistakes left by his predecessor.

Emboldened after overcoming impeachments in his first term and criminal prosecutions in between his two adminis-

trations and with a tight grip on the Republican-controlled Congress, Trump has embarked on a mission to dismantle parts of the federal government, remake the relationship with America's allies and spark a North American trade war that is compounding economic uncertainty.

"It has been nothing but swift and unrelenting action," Trump said of his opening weeks in office. "The people elected me to do the job, and I am doing it."

Trump, who has billionaire adviser Elon Musk orchestrating his efforts to slash the size and scope of the federal government, said he is working to "reclaim democracy from this unaccount-

able bureaucracy" and threatened federal workers anew with firings if they resist his agenda.

Musk, seated in the House gallery, received a pair of standing ovations from Republicans in the chamber, as Trump exaggerated and shared false claims about alleged government abuse uncovered by Musk and his team.

Trump repeated false claims that tens of millions of dead people over 100 years old are receiving Social Security payments, prompting some Democrats to shout, "Not true!" and "Those are lies!"

Trump spoke at a critical juncture in his presidency, as voters who returned him to the White House on his promise to fix

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Makenna Krabath, 15, puts her hand up to signal to cars to stop while walking with Cindy Bergeron, right, a teacher for the visually impaired with Northwest Suburban Special Education Organization, during a field trip to downtown Chicago on Feb. 26. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Learning to navigate Chicago without audible warning signals

Visually impaired students confront hazardous situations

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

On a recent rainy morning in Chicago's Loop, a group of visually impaired students made their way along a sidewalk, sweeping their white canes back and forth to feel curbs and planters. They stopped at a corner to listen. A CTA train roared overhead.

Cars rushed in front of them. They waited. When they could hear the traffic move parallel to them, the group began venturing through the crosswalk, safely reaching the opposite corner.

The suburban students ranged from sixth grade to high school, and their vision varied from pretty good to almost none. Guided by teachers, their crossing was another little victory in a journey to make their way in a world built for sighted people.

"I would get more worried

if I was alone" today, said 10th grader Makenna Krabath, who attends Elk Grove High School. "This makes me feel like I can navigate on my own if I had to."

Every time the kids come to Chicago, they have to confront a hazardous situation — Chicago's lack of audible traffic signals that beep or play announcements to alert people when to cross.

After decades with little response to the problem, a

Turn to Students, Page 2

Fur ban ordinance advances in City Council

Southwest Side furriers say it would end their family-owned businesses

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Chicago was founded by fur traders. Now, it might soon kick them out.

An ordinance banning the sale of new fur products advanced in the City Council on Tuesday, setting up a final vote as soon as next week.

Ald. Raymond Lopez, the ban's author, hopes the move will stifle the "barbaric and inhumane" fur industry, and said existing furriers need to evolve.

"We know we can transition away from formerly live fur products," Lopez, 15th, told aldermen.

But Ald. Matt O'Shea, 19th, and two furriers in his Southwest Side ward warned the ban would be the end of their businesses.

"They are family-owned. They have created jobs for residents in my community. They have contributed to our tax base," O'Shea said. "They will close. People will be out of jobs."

Lopez is the latest Chicago City Council member to court controversy with a proposal aimed at animal rights. North Side Ald. Joe Moore in 2006 got the council to ban foie gras, prohibiting restaurants from serving the delicacy made by force-feeding ducks and

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INSIDE

FOOD & HEALTH



These are a few of your favorite things

A look at the Readers' Choice Food Awards winners: Restaurants, bars, bakeries and more that impressed Chicago in 2024. **Food & Health**

A look at Chicago's endangered buildings

Once anchored by a McDonald's, 150-year-old Delaware Building tops Preservation Chicago's most endangered list. **Business**

TODAY'S WEATHER

High **51**
Low **25**



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